

thinking and behaving.

More such camps followed which brought a much-needed homogeneity among the party workers. Solanki was also responsible for giving them an aim and a vision so that they could root for the Congress when they went about interacting with the masses. "Modi divides Gujarat while the Congress unites it," he tells them. Says Jayesh Thakar, a Congress worker, "By selecting the right worker for the right job and holding a number of training camps for them, Solanki has breathed life into the party."

The first signs of life were visible when party President Sonia Gandhi addressed a tribal rally in the state's Dahod district early this year, where a large number of people turned up, many times more than the expected

leader and lawyer Iqbal Shaikh. Giving nepotism the boot, he even denied a local poll ticket to his aunt and instead chose an ordinary party worker some months ago.

In fact, it is this integrity that has given rise to a number of comparisons between him and Modi. Like Modi, Solanki does not believe in coterie politics and likes to fight a battle rather than arrive at a compromise with the rival. Except for Vaghela, few in Gujarat Congress have demonstrated such a killer instinct. When it comes to firmness in decision-making and implementation, Solanki matches Modi. Says a party worker, "In a way, Solanki has many leadership qualities which are ironically similar to Modi."

But the two have their share of differences as well. Unlike Modi,

vis-a-vis Modi. While Modi is famous for his image as a Hindutva hardliner, Solanki begins the poll game on a negative note with the Congress being weighed down by Muslim-appeasement charges. As Modi likens the Gujarat Congress to the Muslim League, Solanki is bound to find the going tough.

The beleaguered Congress could not have found a better leader to tackle Modi than Solanki. He is a determined fighter, doesn't compromise on the party's ideology, is tech-savvy and does not hesitate in calling a spade a spade. Above all, he is a good election strategist with a vision. Late Madhavrao Scindia had developed a great respect for Solanki as an election strategist, when in the 1999 Madhya Pradesh elections, the party was able to win a large number of seats in the Gwalior region. Even when he was secretary in AICC, he had impressed the bosses with his election strategies.

This time round, he has planned out a high-tech campaign, which, he says, is set to surprise not just the BJP but his own partymen as well. But all this may come to a naught. A retired Congress leader points out, "His determined attitude and vision for the party are perfectly in place. But he does not have the means to implement it because despite his best efforts he can do little about the party's corroded structure at the grassroots."

Now that the battle lines have been drawn up, the confidence level in the Congress camp is high. "This time, the people of Gujarat are going to bless us," asserts Solanki. Even those who had earlier mocked his penchant for discipline and unconventional ways and had dubbed it as a recipe for disaster, have now started looking at him with a new-found interest and hope. However, it remains to be seen whether Solanki would be able to win the Gujarat cup à la Kabir Khan in *Chak De! India* for Modi is as formidable an opposition as the Aussies. Bring on the popcorn! ■



SUMEET INDER SINGH

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one lakh. The Congress gave yet another proof of increased activity when it carried out its threat of holding demonstrations at the state secretariat as part of its "remove Modi" campaign last month. Thousands of party workers braved a police assault to reach the secretariat—this after several years of playing politics of compromise and short-term gains.

This turnaround in the Congress also has its roots in Solanki's discipline. After he became president, he banned the use of cell phones in his chamber. "He seems harsh at times, but that ruthlessness is needed to put the party back on track," says party

Solanki, an engineering graduate, maintains a low profile and prefers to stay away from limelight. He addresses the media only when it is necessary. Right now, he has left the task of attacking the chief minister and his policies to his colleague Modhawadia, who is the leader of the Opposition in the state Assembly. And though he does whatever is correct, he is careful enough to take all factions into confidence, something Modi does not do. "I have moulded myself into a robot who is driven only by the party's interest and nothing else," says Solanki.

In a state as saffronised as Gujarat, Solanki faces a huge disadvantage